

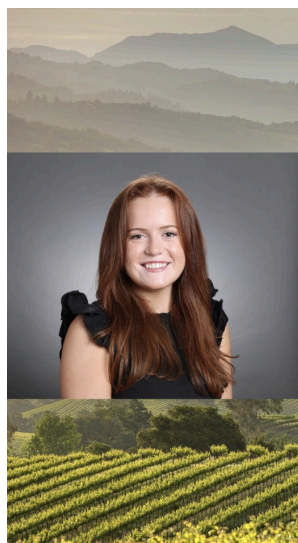
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Internship Reflection

Overview

This summer, I had the privilege of interning with the Sales Leadership Development Program (SLDP) at Gallo in Northern California. From shadowing sales professionals on both the supplier and distributor sides of the wine and spirits industry, to learning directly from retail chain representatives, to receiving field-based sales training, the experience was an incredible opportunity for growth. Gallo's SLDP is a multi-phase, accelerated rotational program designed to develop young professionals into best-in-class sales leaders within the beverage alcohol industry. The program provides exposure across retail chain accounts, district and area sales management, business and market development, product innovation, customer development, and hands-on sales training. The internship itself was an intensive, full-time, eight-week program that combined supplier- and distributor-side learning.

As an intern, I was actively involved in shadow days, participated in field-based sales training, completed modules ranging from Gallo's performance standards to wine knowledge, and developed a capstone project that I presented to Bay Area-based directors and managers. I was also elected Chief Marketing Officer (CMO) of my intern cohort, where I led content creation, coordinated photo collection, and generated ideas for social media coverage of the internship experience. Highlights of the program included traveling to Chicago to gain insight into a new regional market and connect with sales representatives and fellow interns, as well as visiting Gallo's headquarters in Modesto to learn more about the company's history, mission, and vision for the future.



My Accomplishments

Leadership

Team Chief Marketing Officer (CMO)
 Intern Town Hall Leader & Facilitator

Engagement

Shadow Days
 Chicago Market Visit

Personal Development

Industry Education
 Networking Efforts
 Relationship Building

My Learning Experience

Although my time at Gallo was brief, this internship was one of the most intense and rewarding learning experiences I could have gained in just eight weeks. The beverage industry is an incredibly robust, complex, and competitive space, especially within wine and spirits retail. As a major industry leader, Gallo has developed, acquired, and partnered with over 130 wine, spirits, and (recently) beer brands. Their marketing and business development teams have built strategic partnerships with influencers, leading food brands, and major organizations including the NFL, NHL, UFC, and PGA of America. On the retail side, Gallo's salesforce drives brand impressions through creative and compelling displays and cross-merchandising opportunities that boost sales and build brand familiarity with consumers.

One of my greatest takeaways from the summer was learning about current trends in the industry. The wine category is facing significant challenges: Gen Z is drinking less than previous generations, consumers are overwhelmed, even paralyzed, by the sheer number of wine SKUs, and wine is often seen as exclusive, confusing, and unapproachable. In contrast, Ready-to-Drink (RTD) canned cocktails, like High Noon, Cutwater, and BeatBox, are exploding in popularity. For our final project, we were challenged to propose a new product or reposition one of Gallo's existing brands to reach a new audience. My concept was called *Sailor's Sips*, a Ready-to-Drink white wine inspired by one of Gallo's most popular wines, Whitehaven Sauvignon Blanc. Targeted toward newly Legal Drinking Age (LDA) men who value quality, convenience, and social settings, *Sailor's Sips* comes in a stubby glass bottle with a pull-tab opener. The product is positioned to compete directly with leading RTD cocktail brands as well as premium beers, bridging the gap between wine tradition and modern drinking trends.

Sailor's Sips by Whitehaven





Packaging:

- 12 oz "stubby" glass bottle
- Inspired by Bundaberg/Coors Banquet shape
- HIGH ABV - 13%
- Pull-tab cap for easy access

Product Details:

- Ready-to-drink (RTD) Sauvignon Blanc
- Grapes sourced from general New Zealand winegrowing region
 - Lower input costs to enable competitive pricing

Pricing Strategy:

- Retail: \$4.99 per bottle / \$19.99 per 4-pack
- On-Premise: \$11-13 per bottle

Positioning Goal:

- Priced and packaged to compete directly with RTD beer/seltzer/canned cocktail options

The goal of this product is to tackle three key barriers of wine drinking:

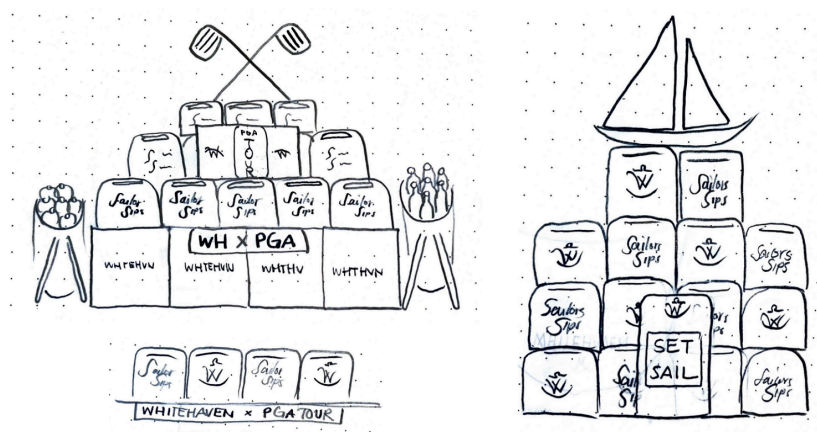
(1) Inconvenience of Complexity: The act of drinking wine takes many steps. You need to know what wine you like to drink. You (likely) need an opener and proper glassware. You need to chill it to the correct temperature. Sailor's Sips simplifies the process through its RTD design.

(2) Accessibility: Wine is (usually) sold in its own section, which many customers entirely avoid. Giving them the opportunity to try Sauvignon Blanc in a casual format, positioned on the shelf they normally shop, promotes trial by new customers.

(3) Intimidation of Formality: an important aspect of GALLO's mission is to "democratize" wine, or make it inviting for new, diverse audiences. Many people stray away from purchasing wine because they are intimidated by it and don't know where to start. Creating a casual RTD format of wine makes the product more approachable for casual beer and seltzer drinkers.

Additionally, I recommended that Whitehaven Sailor's Sips sponsor the PGA Tour to better reach the new LDA male target audience. This will allow for exciting in-store display opportunities and will help promote brand awareness and credibility. *See Below.*

IN-STORE ACTIVATIONS



(I drew these displays to be activated in retail chain accounts)

Features

- 1 Ready-to-drink
- 2 Masculine feel
- 3 Bold & Preppy Label
- 4 Unique Packaging
- 5 Growing Brand

Benefits

- Offers convenience and portability
- Attracts male demographic to the wine category
- Stands out on shelves
- Differentiates from typical bottle shapes
- Leverages Whitehaven's strong, growing reputation

The Surprises of Working at GALLO

Reflecting on my internship, what surprised me most was how intentional Gallo is about hiring people with shared traits, motivations, and leadership experience for the Sales Leadership Development Program. I was one of seven interns in the Northern California cohort, and I can confidently say I finished the summer with seven new close friends. It's no surprise that Gallo has earned multiple awards as one of the best places to work. The company truly values its people and fosters an incredibly positive culture. While the role of an SLDP Sales Representative is demanding and requires grit, the program is designed to encourage bonding, support, and genuine connection beyond just the work. By focusing on hiring like-minded, driven, leadership-oriented individuals, Gallo creates a team dynamic where sales leaders, from entry-level representatives to area managers, work together cohesively and productively.

At the end of my internship, after demonstrating my learning and growth, I was thrilled to receive and accept a full-time offer as a Sales Representative in the Bay Area. What strikes me most is how natural the entire process has felt, from my very first interview to the moment I received my return offer phone call. I am deeply grateful to this company and to the many incredible people it has brought into my life.

Applying my Learning to my Future Career

One of the biggest takeaways from my internship is how much more confident I feel communicating in professional settings. Whether it was presenting my capstone project to directors, participating in sales shadow days, or even just networking with other interns and managers, I learned how to tailor my message depending on the audience while staying clear, concise, and confident. In my sales training, I was challenged to navigate difficult conversations and pitches with different personality types. Those experiences taught me the importance of preparation, but also the value of being adaptable and conversational. These are skills that I know will carry into future interviews, presentations, and everyday professional dialogue.

Moving forward, I feel better equipped to present my ideas in a way that balances professionalism with authenticity. I now have real experience speaking to leadership, collaborating with peers, and representing a brand, which makes me much more comfortable stepping into high-stakes conversations. I see this internship as not just a learning opportunity for sales, but as a foundation for how I'll carry myself in any professional setting. I am feeling very equipped to begin my role as a full time sales representative next Fall.

EMPAC Insights

An aspect of the EMPAC model that I find beautifully aligns with Gallo's sales objectives is "convenience." Since wine can be an overwhelming category for shoppers, Gallo prioritizes convenience and impulse purchasing when programming retail display activations. Whether it be including award call-outs on labels, placing items on the eye-level position on the shelf, relying on credible partnerships (such as Barefoot Wine's sponsorship of the NFL) for in-store

activations, or selling in eye-catching cross-merchandising opportunities, convenience is at the forefront of making a wine sale in a retail environment.